assembled rocket was to be shifted from the church building to the launch pad by truck. When the rocket was lifted by the crane and was about to be placed on the launcher, it started tilting, indicating a leak in the hydraulic system of the crane. As we were fast approaching the launch time, 6 p.m., any repairs to the crane had to be ruled out. Fortunately, the leak was not large and we managed to lift the rocket manual y, using our col ective muscle power and final y placing it on the launcher.

In the maiden Nike-Apache launch, I was in charge of rocket integration and safety. Two of my col eagues who played a very active and crucial role in this launch were D Easwardas and R Aravamudan. Easwardas undertook the rocket assembly and arranged the launch. Aravamudan, whom we cal ed Dan, was in charge of radar, telemetry and ground support. The launch was smooth and problemfree. We obtained excel ent flight data and returned with a sense of pride and accomplishment.

When we were relaxing the next evening at the dinner table, we received news of the assassination of President John F Kennedy in Dal as, Texas. We were appal ed. The Kennedy years were a significant era in America, when